

Digital Safety for College Students • Session 5: When Pictures Are Used Against You: Image-Based Abuse and Sextortion

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

FIELD COPY

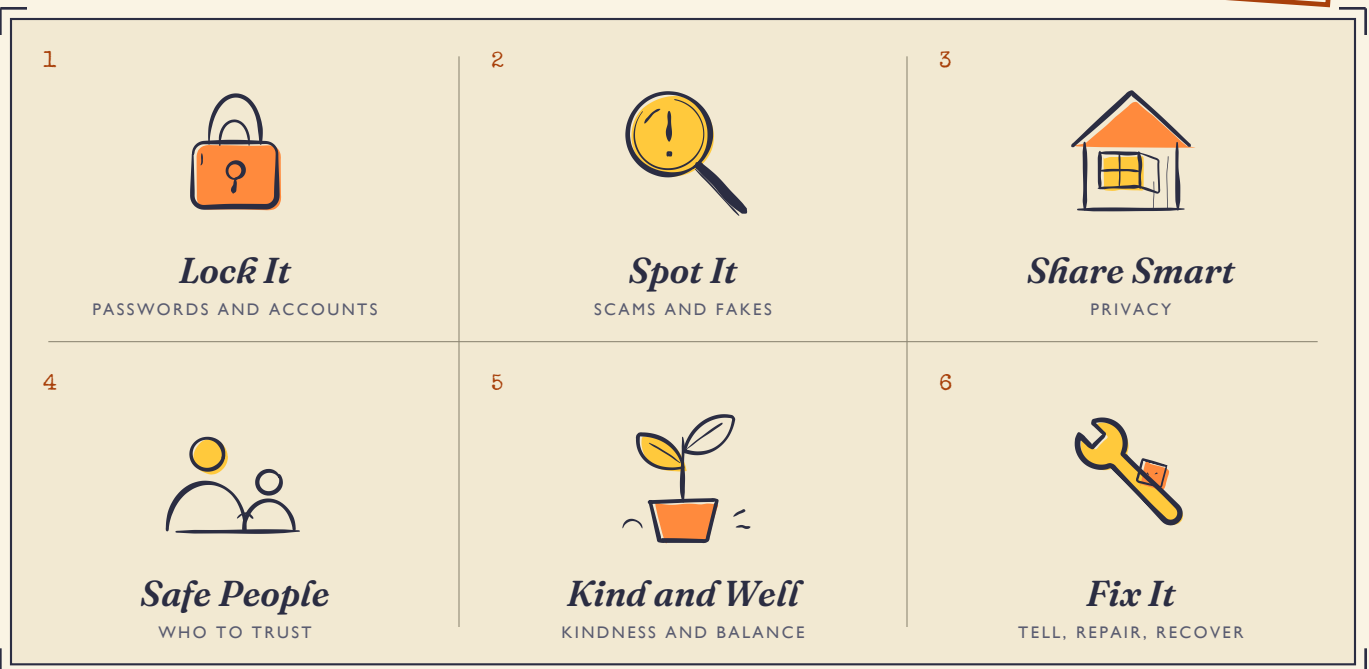


PLATE I. The six strands, hand-linked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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TO VERIFY

Status: **DRAFT for campus review.** Items in [BRACKETS] are local blanks to fill in. Items marked [VERIFY] need a source check. Items marked [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] need review by the college's counsel, Title IX coordinator or student-affairs leadership before use. This is educational material and is not legal advice.

At a glance

SPECIMEN LABEL	
LENGTH	50 minutes
WHO	Students aged about 17 to 24 in first-year seminars, orientation, student success courses, residence life and clubs. Works for groups of 8 to 40.
TOPICS	Sextortion and romance scams, non-consensual sharing of intimate images, fake intimate images, what to do, StopNCII for adults, campus resources, supporting a friend.
LED BY	A trained facilitator (faculty, staff, peer educator) with a campus counselor or advocate on call for Sessions 5 and 6
MATERIALS	Slides for Session 5; Content note card (read aloud at the start); Reply-writing cards 5A to 5F; Local resource sheet; Campus Safety Card; Evaluation card

NO STUDENT ACCOUNTS, NO student data collected, ever. The evaluation card is anonymous.

Objectives

By the end of the session, students can:

- Describe how sextortion and image-based abuse start, using the language of the pattern and without shame.
- State the first-hour steps: stop, save, tell, report, and do not pay.
- Choose the right removal service: StopNCII for adults, Take It Down for images made when under 18, CyberTipline for any image of a minor.
- Know campus options: counseling, Title IX office, campus police, advocates, and what each can and cannot keep private.
- Write a first reply to a friend who tells you this has happened to them.

Before you start (about 20 minutes of prep)

- ☐ Meet with [COUNSELING CENTER] and [TITLE IX OFFICE] before this session. Confirm which resources are confidential and which staff are reporting employees, and write that on the slide. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]
- ☐ Invite a counselor or advocate to be present or on call during the session. This is strongly recommended.
- ☐ Check each hotline detail against the Campus Safety Card [VERIFY before printing].
- ☐ Show no images. Use no graphic detail. Never ask a student to describe their own experience. Never ask a student to play a person who was harmed or a person who caused harm.
- ☐ Read the master disclosure protocol in the Facilitator Guide and the session-specific notes below.
- ☐ Print the Campus Safety Card with local blanks filled in.

Agenda

MINUTES	SEGMENT
0 to 5	Open: a content note and the ground rules
5 to 13	Sextortion, romance scams and image-based abuse
13 to 21	Supporting a friend, and where to go on campus
21 to 36	Activity: Reply-Writing Round
36 to 44	Discussion
44 to 50	Takeaway and evaluation card

Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. In this module the idea has the same four steps for adults. Hackles up is the noticing step: a prickle that something is too good, too urgent, too secret or just a little off. Pause means nothing has to happen in the next five minutes. Check means confirming through a door you opened yourself, such as a known phone number or the official app. Tell means bringing in a person; a false alarm costs little, and if you were fooled anyway it is never your fault.

Facilitator script

LINES IN THE SCRIPT are written to be said in your own voice. Change the words freely; keep the facts. Items in [BRACKETS] are local.

0 TO 5 MINUTES: OPEN: A CONTENT NOTE AND THE GROUND RULES

I want to give a content note before we begin. This session is about the misuse of private or intimate images, and about people being blackmailed. It does not include any images or graphic detail. You can step out at any time and return when you wish, and [COUNSELOR OR ADVOCATE] is available in [LOCATION] during and after this session. No one will be asked to share a personal experience.

A word about privacy. If you decide to tell me something personal during or after class, I will want to tell you first what I can and cannot keep private. [As a staff member I may have to pass certain information to the Title IX office. COUNSEL TO CONFIRM.] If you would prefer a confidential resource, [COUNSELING CENTER] is that, and I will walk you there. You will not be in trouble for anything that was done to you.

The main message is one I want you to hear first. If someone has used an image, a recording or a threat against you, you are the person who was wronged. It does not matter whether you sent the image willingly, whether you trusted them, or what the picture shows. Shame is how this works for the person who is doing it. A well-informed response breaks that.

5 TO 13 MINUTES: SEXTORTION, ROMANCE SCAMS AND IMAGE-BASED ABUSE

Sextortion means a threat to share intimate images or information unless you pay or do something else. It can target adults of any gender. A common version starts on a social or dating app with a new, attractive profile that moves the conversation to a private app very quickly, trades photos, and then the "friend" says that they have your photos and will send them to your contacts unless you pay. Sometimes the account was made from stolen pictures, and sometimes the images were fabricated or edited, and the threat works even then. Romance scams follow a related path: someone you have never met in person builds closeness, then invents a crisis, such as a flight, a medical bill or a customs fee, and asks for money, and refuses to appear on live video.

Image-based abuse covers a wider set of harms. An ex-partner shares private images. A group chat passes around a picture that was meant for one person. Someone makes a fake intimate image from an ordinary photo. Many states have laws against sharing intimate images without consent, and some cover fakes [VERIFY for your state]. There is also a federal law about removal of non-consensual intimate images by covered platforms [VERIFY: the TAKE IT DOWN Act, scope and dates]. Campus policy may also apply, and Title IX or conduct processes may be available [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM how your college handles this]. You decide whether to use them.

Now the response. **Stop. Save. Tell. Report.** Stop: do not reply and do not pay. Cooperating or paying rarely stops the blackmail, according to the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children [VERIFIED in kit: missingkids.org]. Do not delete the account or the conversation yet. Block only after you have saved what you need. Save: usernames, profile links, dates, the threat messages and the payment demand as text or screenshots of the conversation. If any image shows someone who was under 18 when the image was made, do not copy, forward or screenshot it, not even as proof. Tell: a person you trust. Report: the platform's reporting tool; IC3 at ic3.gov for blackmail and internet crime [VERIFY]; and, where relevant, campus police or your Title IX office.

Removal services. StopNCII.org is for adults: you must be the person in the image, 18 or older now and at the time the image was made. The image stays on your device; a digital fingerprint is shared with participating platforms to block it [VERIFIED in kit]. It works only on participating platforms. Whether it handles AI-generated images is unclear [VERIFY]. If the image was made when you were under 18, even if you are an adult now, use Take It Down at takeitdown.ncmec.org instead, which works the same way [VERIFIED in kit]. If any image of a person under 18 is involved, NCMEC's CyberTipline takes reports at report.cybertip.org or 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED in kit].

13 TO 21 MINUTES: SUPPORTING A FRIEND, AND WHERE TO GO ON CAMPUS

If a friend tells you, you are being given trust. Your first words matter. "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. What do you need right now?" Avoid "How could you send that?" and "Why did you trust them?" Avoid taking over: do not message the person who is threatening your friend, and do not ask to see the pictures. Offer to sit with them while they report, to go with them to [COUNSELING CENTER], to help them save the evidence, to help with StopNCII or Take It Down, or just to stay close.

Threats like this can make a person feel desperate and alone. If a friend says they cannot take it anymore, or talks about hurting themselves, stay with them, ask directly whether they are thinking about suicide, and connect them with help right away: call or text 988, or text HOME to 741741 for Crisis Text Line, or take them to [COUNSELING CENTER OR CRISIS WALK-IN]. If they are in immediate danger, call 911 or [CAMPUS POLICE].

On campus. [COUNSELING CENTER] offers support and, in most cases, confidentiality [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]. [VICTIM ADVOCATE, if any] helps with options without requiring a report. [TITLE IX OFFICE] can explain supportive measures and the process, and can tell you what they must do after you tell them [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]. [CAMPUS POLICE] can take a report and explain criminal options. You can contact any of them just to ask questions. A useful sentence: "I want to understand my options, and I want to know what you would be required to share."

Activity (15 minutes): Reply-Writing Round

Set-up

- Pairs or trios. Each pair receives two printed cards, each with a short text message from a fictional friend or a fictional situation described in the third person.
- The students write a reply. They do not act out the person in the message, and no student plays a person who threatens or shares images.
- Handout: the Say This, Not That list (Facilitator Guide, Appendix B). Facilitator or counselor circulates.

Steps

1. Read the card silently or aloud. (1 min)
2. Write a first reply of two or three sentences. Use at least one of: believe, not your fault, ask what they need, offer a next step. (4 min per card)
3. Swap with another pair. Read their reply and underline anything that is shaming, bossy or vague; circle the helpful parts. (2 min)
4. Whole-group debrief (Discussion).

SCENARIO CARDS (PRINT AND CUT; EVERY CARD IS A FICTIONAL COMPOSITE)

Names and details are invented. Any resemblance to a real student is accidental. Change names if one matches a student in your room.

Card 5A The 24-hour threat

Lena texts you: "Someone I met online says they have my photos and will send them to everyone I know unless I pay \$300 in gift cards by tomorrow. I did send one picture. I am so stupid."

Card 5B The group chat

Your friend Rashad writes: "My ex posted a private photo of me in a group chat. Everyone in my dorm has seen it. I want to disappear."

Card 5C The fake

Pilar tells you: "Somebody made a fake nude of me from my profile picture and it is going around. It is not even me. It still feels awful."

Card 5D The flight money

Dario says: "There is a guy I have been talking to for two months. He lives overseas, has never video called, and needs \$1,200 for a plane ticket to visit me. He says he loves me."

Card 5E The old picture

A 19-year-old writes: "When I was 16 I sent a photo to someone. Now he is threatening to post it."

Card 5F I cannot take this

Late at night a friend texts: "I cannot take this anymore. They are going to send it to my parents."

ROLE-PLAY PRACTICE (NO STUDENT PLAYS A VICTIM OR AN OFFENDER)

Practice the first sentence. Pairs. Each partner reads aloud, from a card, the sentence a person might say to start the conversation with a campus office: "I would like to understand my options, and I would like to know what you would be required to share." The other reads the staff reply printed on the card: "Thank you for coming in. I will tell you what I can keep private and what I cannot, and then you can decide." This is practice with the wording of a question anyone is entitled to ask. Neither partner plays a person who was harmed or a person who caused harm.

FACILITATOR KEY

Keep moving. Do not ask anyone to say whether they or someone they know has been affected. Hand out the Say This, Not That list from the Facilitator Guide. Say "Thank you for telling me" and "This is not your fault" and "What do you need right now?" Avoid "Why did you send it?" and "You should have known" and "Let me see it."

CARD	WHAT TO LISTEN FOR
5A The 24-hour threat	Key: not stupid; stop contact and do not pay; save messages and usernames; report to the platform and ic3.gov [VERIFY]; Take It Down if she was under 18 when the picture was made; offer to go to [COUNSELING CENTER] together.
5B The group chat	Key: believe; not his fault; ask about safety; offer options (platform report, StopNCII if he was 18 or older when it was made, Title IX office, campus police); mention 988 gently, ask directly about suicide; do not ask to see the photo.
5C The fake	Key: it is still real harm; save links and dates; report to platforms; StopNCII may help for adults, though coverage for fakes is unclear [VERIFY]; campus policy may apply [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]; support her feelings.
5D The flight money	Key: gentle, no mockery. Offer to help check: video call request, reverse image search of the profile photos, talk to someone before sending money. Mention reportfraud.ftc.gov [VERIFIED in kit] and ic3.gov [VERIFY]. This is a romance scam pattern.
5E The old picture	Key: because the image was made when under 18, this goes to NCMEC: Take It Down and the CyberTipline [VERIFIED in kit]; do not copy or forward the photo; the person is not in trouble; reporting duties may apply to an adult who hears this [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY state law]; tell [COUNSELING CENTER] and campus police.
5F I cannot take this	Key: ask directly about suicide; stay connected; 988 or Crisis Text Line; go to them or arrange someone safe nearby; call 911 or [CAMPUS POLICE] if there is immediate danger; do not leave them alone.

Discussion (8 minutes)

- What made the replies you underlined feel unhelpful? What would you want to hear if it were you?
- Why do you think shame is so central in these situations? How can a group of friends or a residence hall reduce it?
- What stops people from reporting? What would make reporting feel safer on this campus?
- Which tool or contact on the Campus Safety Card will you save in your phone today?
- Close with a breath or a stretch. Offer the counselor's location again.

Takeaway (read aloud, then hand out the evaluation card)

FIELD NOTE

No. 1

This is never the victim's fault. Stop, save, tell, report, and do not pay. StopNCII is for adults, Take It Down is for images made under 18, and the CyberTipline is for any image of a minor. Campus counseling, advocates, the Title IX office and campus police are all places to ask questions.

If a student discloses

TO VERIFY

Never promise confidentiality you cannot give. Title IX responsible-employee duties and campus reporting rules vary by institution and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY current federal rules and state law]. Before the session, find out which category you are in, and say so to students.

Master steps (the same in every session):

1. **Say the heads-up first.** If a student starts to tell you something personal, pause them kindly before the details: "Thank you. Before you go on, I want you to know what I can and cannot keep private. [As a staff member I may have to share some of this with the Title IX office. COUNSEL TO CONFIRM your role.] If you would rather talk with someone who can keep it confidential, I can walk you to [COUNSELING CENTER]." Then let the student choose.
1. **Listen and believe.** Stay calm. "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault." Skip the "why" questions. Let the student use their own words.
1. **Do not investigate.** Ask only what you need to connect them with help: are you safe right now, and what would help most today? Never ask to see images, messages or accounts. Do not contact the other person.
1. **Never promise confidentiality or outcomes you cannot give.** Say what you will do and who you will tell. Responsible-employee duties under Title IX and campus policy vary by institution and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY current federal rules and your state law].
1. **Offer choices.** Counseling, a victim advocate, the Title IX office, campus police, the platform's report form, or none of these today. The student decides what to do next whenever the law and policy allow.

1. **Make a warm handoff.** Offer to walk with them, sit beside them during the call, or help write the email. A phone number on a card is a weaker handoff than a person.
1. **Safety first.** Immediate danger: 911 or campus police. Thoughts of suicide or self-harm: stay with the student, bring in the counseling center or a crisis line, and use 988 (call or text 988) or Crisis Text Line (text HOME to 741741).
1. **If a minor is involved** (an image of someone under 18, or a child at risk), reporting duties may apply to you as an adult, and they differ by state and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY state law]. Do not copy, forward or screenshot such an image. Direct the student to NCMEC's CyberTipline and Take It Down.
1. **Write it down afterward.** Record the student's words and what you said and did, as your policy requires. Share with others only on a need-to-know basis. Talk with your supervisor about what you heard so you are not carrying it alone.

Specific to this session:

- This is the session where a disclosure is most likely. Have a counselor or advocate present or on call. If a student begins, use the heads-up from the master protocol before the details. Do not ask to see messages or images.
- If the student was under 18 when an image was made, or if a minor is involved, reporting duties may apply to you [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY state law]. Say so plainly and offer the student a choice of who goes with them.
- If the student has thoughts of suicide, stay with them and bring in crisis support right away: 988, Crisis Text Line (text HOME to 741741), [COUNSELING CENTER] or 911 and [CAMPUS POLICE].
- Do not promise that an image will be removed, that the person will be prosecuted, or that a report will lead to a particular outcome.

Accessibility and inclusion notes

For this session:

- Offer an alternative for students who want to opt out of the activity: they can read the Say This, Not That card and leave, or work on the resource sheet.
- For students whose cultural or family context makes these topics especially charged, name the counseling center as a place where private questions are welcome. Offer interpreters on request [LOCAL].

- LGBTQ+ students may face threats of outing as part of sextortion. Say that plainly, and name [CAMPUS LGBTQ+ CENTER, if any] and confidential resources.
- Students who are parents may worry that disclosure leads to child-welfare involvement. Do not speculate; say that [COUNSELING CENTER] can explain their own situation in confidence [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].

For every session:

- **International students.** Scam scripts, institutions and legal systems differ by country, and some scams exploit visa fears. Say plainly that a real college or government office will not demand payment in gift cards, and point to the international student office as a place to check any message about status. Use plain English, avoid idioms, share slides ahead of time, and let students use a translation tool during activities. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM: any reporting duties that apply to international students' status information; do not speculate about immigration consequences in class.]
- **Students with disabilities.** Send slides and cards in advance in accessible formats (the decks are built with real slide titles, reading order and speaker notes). Use captions for any video. Read cards aloud for anyone who wants that. Allow extra time. Disability services can advise on assistive technology. Do not require anyone to speak, write by hand or move around the room.
- **First-generation students.** Do not assume anyone knows how financial aid, housing contracts or campus offices work. Name the real office and what it does. Describe the normal process before you describe the scam version of it.
- **Students who are parents or caregivers.** Evening and commuter schedules often mean children in the background or a short window to attend. Allow children in the room for lecture portions where the content suits it, and offer the printed cards for take-home. Examples that involve a child's photos or school should be framed around the adult's choices.
- **Commuter and evening students.** Offer a recorded or self-paced version of the same content with the same cards [LOCAL: confirm your platform's accessibility and privacy settings]. Keep sessions on time. Provide the handouts as one page so they fit a bag or a phone screen.
- **Everyone.** Participation is always optional. Offer a Pass card, a written question box, and a clear way to step out and return. Use content notes before heavy material, and show no images of the harms discussed.

Local resource table (fill in before the session)

NEED	WHO	HOW
Immediate danger	911, or [CAMPUS POLICE EMERGENCY NUMBER]	Call
Campus police, non-emergency	[CAMPUS POLICE NON-EMERGENCY NUMBER]	Call or walk in
Campus counseling center	[COUNSELING CENTER NAME, PHONE, LOCATION, HOURS] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM whether it is a confidential resource]	Call or walk in
Title IX office	[TITLE IX COORDINATOR NAME, EMAIL, PHONE] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM how reports are handled]	Email or call
Dean of students or student affairs	[OFFICE, PHONE, LOCATION]	Walk in
Financial aid and bursar	[OFFICE, PHONE, LOCATION]	Walk in or call the number on the college website
IT help desk and security	[HELP DESK PHONE, EMAIL, LOCATION]	Call or walk in
International student office	[OFFICE, PHONE]	Walk in
Disability services	[OFFICE, PHONE]	Walk in
Health center or victim advocate	[NAME, PHONE] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM confidentiality]	Call
Suicide or crisis support	988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988; chat at 988lifeline.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Text-based crisis support	Crisis Text Line	Text HOME to 741741 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Intimate images shared or threatened (you were 18 or older when the image was made)	StopNCII.org	stopncii.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Intimate images made when you were under 18	NCMEC Take It Down	takeitdown.ncmec.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Sextortion, or any image of someone under 18	NCMEC CyberTipline	report.cybertip.org or 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Blackmail and internet crime	FBI IC3	ic3.gov [VERIFY]
Scams and fraud	FTC	reportfraud.ftc.gov [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Identity theft	FTC	identitytheft.gov [VERIFY]
Dating abuse and controlling relationships	loveisrespect	Call 1-866-331-9474 or text LOVEIS to 22522; loveisrespect.org [VERIFY before printing]

RE-VERIFY EVERY NUMBER AND address before printing. Hotline details marked **VERIFIED** were checked in the Hackles verification rounds dated 2026-10-05 and should still be re-checked before any print run.

Evaluation card (anonymous; print four per page)

Evaluation cards are anonymous. Do not collect names, student ID numbers or email addresses. Tally counts only (for example, how many students circled each number). Aggregate results can go to your supervisor; individual cards are recycled after tallying [LOCAL: confirm records policy].

Session 5: Image-based abuse and sextortion for adults

- I feel more able to spot a problem like the ones we discussed today. (1 = not at all, 5 = very much) 1 2 3 4 5
- I know where on campus I could go for help with this topic. (1 = not at all, 5 = very much) 1 2 3 4 5
- One person or office on campus I could contact about this is: _____
- What would make this session better?
- Anything you want the facilitator to know? (Do not include names or personal details.)

Facilitator reflection (after the session, for your own notes)

- What went well? What would I change in the timing?
- Which card sparked the best discussion?
- Did a student disclose? Did I follow the protocol and write it down? Who did I debrief with?
- Which local blanks still need filling in?

Sources and verification notes

- Sextortion response steps and the claim that paying rarely stops it, per NCMEC. [VERIFIED in kit, Round 3A D1]
- StopNCII eligibility and process. [VERIFIED in kit, Round 3A D5]
- Take It Down for images made under 18. [VERIFIED in kit, Round 3A D3]
- State laws on non-consensual intimate images and fakes. [VERIFY]
- The federal TAKE IT DOWN Act, scope and dates. [VERIFY]
- Reporting duties for adults who learn of images of minors. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY]
- IC3 for blackmail reports. [VERIFY]

- Hotline and reporting details are taken from the kit's [VERIFY_Checklist](#) and the 9-12 Teacher Guide appendix C1. Re-check before printing.
- Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled study. It does not replace campus counseling, Title IX processes, legal advice or emergency services.